

Counsellor Prospects & Notes Companion

An independent companion tool for admissions counsellors — built alongside Meritto CRM, not inside it

Plan of Action — Product & Build Specification
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1. Executive Summary

Counsellors currently manage all leads inside Meritto CRM, which is built around a rigid, stage-based pipeline. This works well for qualified leads moving toward admission, but it has no good home for ‘tentative’ prospects — people who are lukewarm, undecided, or asked to be followed up later. These leads quietly fall through the cracks because the CRM was not designed to hold that kind of nuance.

This plan proposes a standalone companion tool, intentionally kept independent of Meritto, that gives each counsellor a personal, low-friction space to track tentative prospects, jot quick notes, and start their day with a personalized welcome message. It also includes a cross-counsellor admin portal so leadership has visibility across the whole team and duplicate lead claims are caught automatically.

Core modules to build:

- **Prospects Tab** — personal, temperature-based tracking of tentative leads (manual add + CSV bulk import)
- **Notes Tab** — quick, searchable personal notes, optionally linked to a prospect
- **Daily Welcome Message** — personalized greeting on login, driven by the counsellor's own activity
- **Admin Portal** — org-wide visibility, duplicate-conflict resolution, and aggregate analytics

2. Problem Statement

- Meritto's stage-based pipeline forces a binary state; it can't hold ‘maybe, follow up later’ leads gracefully.
- Tentative leads get buried under daily task lists and silently go cold.
- There is no lightweight space for a counsellor's own working notes and reminders.
- When two counsellors independently note interest from the same lead, there is no way to catch the overlap — risking duplicate, awkward outreach to the same prospect.
- Leadership has no aggregate view of common objections, stale prospects, or informal pipeline health.

3. Feature Specification

3.1 Prospects Tab

The primary daily-use surface. Adding a prospect should take under 10 seconds via a persistent “+ Add Prospect” action.

- Fields: Name, Phone, Email, Course(s) of interest (multi-select), Temperature (Hot / Warm / Cold), Concern tags + note, Next follow-up date, Status.
- Status values: Active, Snoozed, Nurture / Future Intake, Converted (Partial / Full), Lost.
- Smart views: “Due today” and “Going cold” (untouched 5+ days) surfaced automatically.
- Future / Nurture bucket: tagged to a target intake cycle, longer default check-in cadence, auto-resurfaces as that cycle approaches.

3.2 Notes Tab

- Sticky-note style quick capture — single keystroke to add, no mandatory fields.
- Pin, search, and optionally link a note to a specific prospect record.

- Kept private to the counsellor by default, even in the admin view.

3.3 Daily Welcome Message

- Personalized from the counsellor's own activity where possible (e.g. "You reconnected with 3 prospects yesterday", follow-up streaks) rather than a generic quote bank.
- Falls back to a short, curated motivational line only when there's no activity data to draw on.
- Designed with restraint: one line, subtle entrance animation, no forced gamification clutter.

3.4 Conversion Logic

Rather than a manual "mark as converted" step (easy to forget under daily call volume), conversion is auto-detected from a fee/token entry the counsellor logs anyway for their own record-keeping:

- Token / partial fee logged → status auto-moves to **Converted – Partial**
- Full fee logged → status auto-moves to **Converted – Full**

4. Data Model

4.1 Prospect Record

Field	Type	Notes
name	Text	Prospect's full name
phone	Text (normalized)	Primary matching key — strip spaces/dashes, standardize country code
email	Text (normalized)	Secondary matching key — trimmed, lower-cased
course_interest	Multi-select	One or more programs the prospect is considering
temperature	Enum	Hot / Warm / Cold
concern_tags	Multi-select + note	Fee, Location, Timing/Intake, Comparing Options, Parental Consent, Eligibility
status	Enum	Active / Snoozed / Nurture / Converted-Partial / Converted-Full / Lost
intake_cycle	Text	Used for Nurture/Future bucket, e.g. 'Spring 2027'
next_follow_up	Date	Drives the 'Due today' view
last_contacted	Date	Drives the 'Going cold' view
owner_counsellor_id	Reference	Set on first claim; used for duplicate resolution
fee_entries[]	List (amount, date)	Triggers auto conversion status
created_at / updated_at	Timestamp	Audit trail

4.2 Note Record

Field	Type	Notes
text	Text	Free-form note content
linked_prospect_id	Reference (optional)	If tied to a specific prospect
pinned	Boolean	Surfaces at top of list
created_at	Timestamp	Sort / search
owner_counsellor_id	Reference	Private by default

5. Duplicate Detection & Ownership Logic

This requires one shared backend across the team with role-based visibility (a counsellor sees their own full records; an admin sees everything) — it cannot be a fully siloed per-counsellor store, since the duplicate check has to run against the whole org's index.

Matching keys, in priority order:

- **Phone number** (primary) — normalized before comparison

- **Email** (secondary) — trimmed, case-insensitive
- **Name** (soft signal only) — never auto-matches; raises a 'possible duplicate?' flag for the counsellor to decide

Ownership rule: first claim wins, by timestamp.

When Counsellor B tries to add a prospect that matches an existing record (via manual add **or** CSV bulk import — both trigger the same real-time check), the system does not block outright. It shows: “Already tracked by [Counsellor A] since [date] — Status: [temperature], Last contacted [date]”, with three resolution paths:

- **View only** — sees status/temperature/course/last-contact date, never the owner's private notes
- **Request ownership transfer** — sent to the current owner, auto-escalates to admin if unanswered
- **Flag as shared interest** — for genuine edge cases (e.g. interest in a different course); creates a linked reference rather than a second independent thread

Every duplicate-claim event — from manual add or CSV import — lands in the admin's Conflict Queue (see Section 7) for fast resolution.

6. CSV Import / Export Workflow

- Downloadable template with fixed columns (Name, Phone, Email, Course Interest, Concern, Notes) — no free-form column mapping guesswork.
- Upload flow: parse → run the same phone/email duplicate check row-by-row → preview/confirm screen before anything commits.
- Rows matching an existing record (own or another counsellor's) are flagged the same way as a manual duplicate — never silently merged or silently duplicated.
- Export: full prospects list downloadable anytime, for offline review, manager sharing, or as a backup safety net since the tool has no live sync to Meritto.

7. Admin Portal

- **Org-wide table** — every counsellor's prospects, filterable by counsellor, course, temperature, concern tag, and days-since-contact.
- **Conflict Queue** — every duplicate claim (manual or CSV) lands here for the admin to reassign, approve-as-shared, or close.
- **Reassignment tool** — for counsellor turnover, workload rebalancing, or escalation.
- **Analytics** — top concern themes across the team, stale-prospect counts per counsellor, tentative-to-converted rate by counsellor.

8. Design Principles

The tool should feel deliberately different from a dense enterprise CRM screen — that contrast is what makes it feel like the counsellor's own space rather than another company system.

- Card-based layout, generous whitespace, soft shadows over dense tables
- One consistent accent color, restrained motion — no gimmicky gamification
- Fast perceived load: skeleton states, optimistic UI updates
- Dark mode toggle
- Mobile-responsive — counsellors should be able to check 'due today' from a phone

9. Phased Roadmap

PHASE 1

MVP — Core Daily-Use Loop

Foundation

- Counsellor login + shared backend with role-based visibility (required from day one for cross-counsellor dedup)
- Prospects tab: manual add with full field set, temperature, concern tags, next follow-up date
- Real-time duplicate check on manual add, with the three resolution paths
- Notes tab: quick capture, pin, search
- Daily welcome message: personalized from activity, quote fallback
- 'Due today' / 'Going cold' smart views

PHASE 2

Bulk Workflows & Conversion

Next

- CSV template download + upload with preview/confirm and row-by-row duplicate checking
- CSV export of the prospects list
- Fee/token payment logging → auto conversion status (Partial / Full)
- Nurture / Future-Intake bucket with intake-cycle tagging and longer check-in cadence

PHASE 3

Admin Portal

Then

- Org-wide prospects table with filters
- Conflict Queue for duplicate-claim resolution
- Manual reassignment tool
- Aggregate analytics: concern themes, stale-prospect counts, conversion rate by counsellor

PHASE 4

Polish

Later

- Visual pass for the premium feel: cards, soft shadows, restrained motion, dark mode
- Daily digest notification (email/WhatsApp) for 'due today' prospects
- Optional, future: revisit a light read-only pull from Meritto if API access ever opens up

10. Suggested Tech Stack

- **Frontend:** mobile-responsive web app (works alongside Meritto on the same desktop, and reachable from a phone)

- **Backend:** shared database with role-based access control (Postgres is a solid default) to support the org-wide duplicate index and admin portal
- **Auth:** per-counsellor login with an admin role tier
- **Hosting:** independent of Meritto's infrastructure entirely, by design

11. Open Questions for Next Discussion

- Notification channel for the daily digest — email, WhatsApp, or in-app only?
- Should admins ever be able to view a counsellor's private notes (e.g. for a performance review), or should that stay fully off-limits?
- Retention policy for 'Lost' prospects — auto-archive after how long?
- Longer-term: is a read-only Meritto API integration worth pursuing once this MVP proves the workflow?

End of document — Counsellor Prospects & Notes Companion, Plan of Action.